

Exploration of Cultural Heritage Interpretation
Pathways from the Perspective of Participatory
Development Theory
—— A Case Study of the "Digital Heritage Project"

Yuxun Wang

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Abstract

In cultural heritage institutions, the innovative transformation of museum interpretation practices is crucial for effectively sharing cultural heritage and realizing its social value. Exploring novel approaches to heritage interpretation not only addresses public demand for cultural engagement but also fosters innovative interpretive practices. Grounded in the perspective of participatory development theory, this study integrates its core concept—facilitating the transformation of marginalized groups from passive recipients to active creators—into the investigation of cultural heritage interpretation pathways. Utilizing case analysis, the study proposes a three-stage model for participatory interpretation, offering a theoretically grounded and practically applicable framework for innovating cultural heritage interpretation methods. The research focuses on how multi-stakeholder involvement can facilitate the transition of heritage interpretation from outcome delivery to process sharing. A hybrid methodology of participatory inquiry and case analysis was adopted, with an intensive two-year follow-up investigation of the “Digital Heritage” project at the Nanjing Great Bao’en Temple Site Museum. The findings indicate that participatory development theory provides a core logic for shared interpretive processes in cultural heritage, emphasizing the shift from closed operations to phased public openness while ensuring interpretation quality through moderate delegation of cultural agency. This approach furnishes a transformative framework from theory to practice for innovating heritage interpretation.

Key words: participatory development theory; cultural heritage; interpretation sharing; interpretation module

Exploring Innovative Development Pathways for Small and Medium-Sized Museums through Youth Co-Creation: A Practical Study Based on International Competitions

Yuxun Wang

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Abstract

Against the backdrop of rapid social transformation and development, small and medium-sized museums, as integral components of the museum system, face numerous practical challenges, including limited collections, subpar exhibition quality, and a shortage of professional curatorial talent. Addressing these issues has become a focal point in museum work in the new era. Youth, as a driving force in social change, bring innovative ideas and capabilities that offer significant insights for museum development. Studying youth communities and gaining an in-depth understanding of their perspectives hold substantial practical importance for helping small and medium-sized museums overcome challenges and achieve innovative growth. Consequently, translating the concept of youth co-creation into practice has emerged as a critical pathway for museum development. Various approaches can facilitate youth co-creation, such as museum-school collaborations, competition organization, and volunteer recruitment. Among these, competitions attract a broader and more diverse youth demographic. This study draws on the author's first-hand involvement in China's inaugural international museum competition, "The Enduring Legacy—Immersive Cultural Heritage Maker Competition," employing participatory observation to examine how such events foster the integration of youth perspectives, facilitate multidisciplinary teamwork, broaden international horizons, and incorporate cutting-edge technologies. Practical outcomes indicate that the competition also serves as a platform for youth professional development, creating a mutually reinforcing cycle that offers new solutions to the existing challenges faced by small and medium-sized museums. The research concludes that international competitions effectively promote youth engagement in museum co-creation, presenting a viable strategy to address current issues in small and medium-sized museums, worthy of broader application and practice.

Key words: small and medium-sized museums; youth co-creation; international competitions